

UPSC PHILOSOPHY OPTIONAL

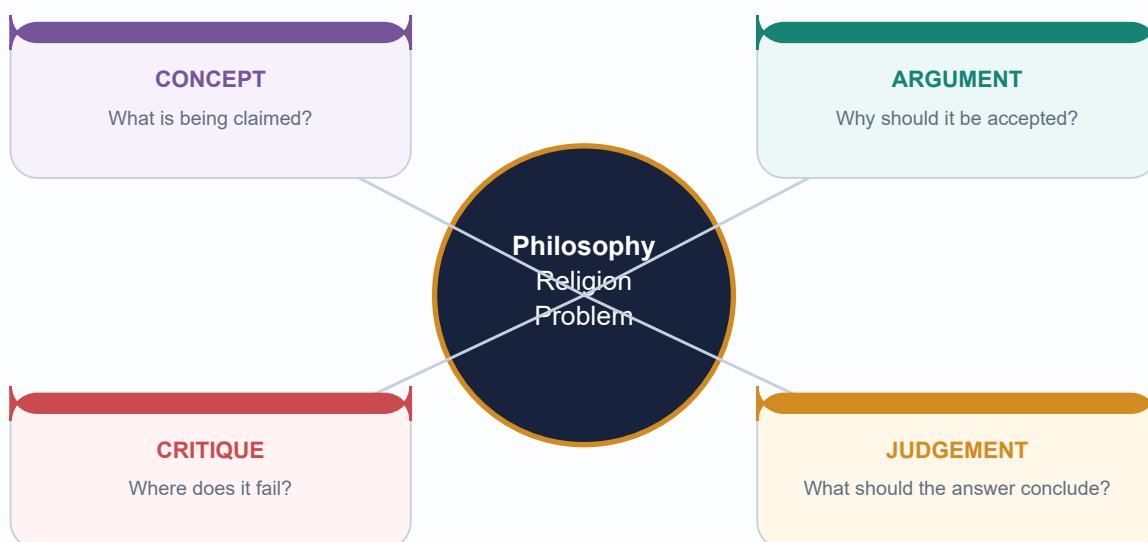
Philosophy of Religion: Problem of Evil

UPSC Philosophy Optional | Paper II | Philosophy of Religion

Syllabus: Problem of Evil.

Direct local-PDF base: John Hick, local PDF pp. 50-66; Oxford Handbook, Problem of Evil chapter (PDF pp. 200-231); C. D. Sharma, karma and liberation discussions across Buddhist, Nyaya and Vedanta chapters. Cross-check: verified Paper-II knowledge note and verbatim 2022-2025 PYQ bank. The sources are strongest on Christian theodicies; Indian material is therefore presented comparatively, not as a single unified doctrine.

Content-rich visual edition: arguments, matrices, Indian perspectives, PYQs and answer frameworks



Facts from official sources | Inferences clearly marked | No fabricated data

HIGH UPSC RELEVANCE

HIGH

Master Argument Tree: Why Evil Challenges Classical Theism

Paper II
Philosophy

INTRO & ORIGIN

Evil becomes a philosophical problem when apparently pointless suffering is placed beside a creator who is all-powerful, all-knowing and perfectly good.

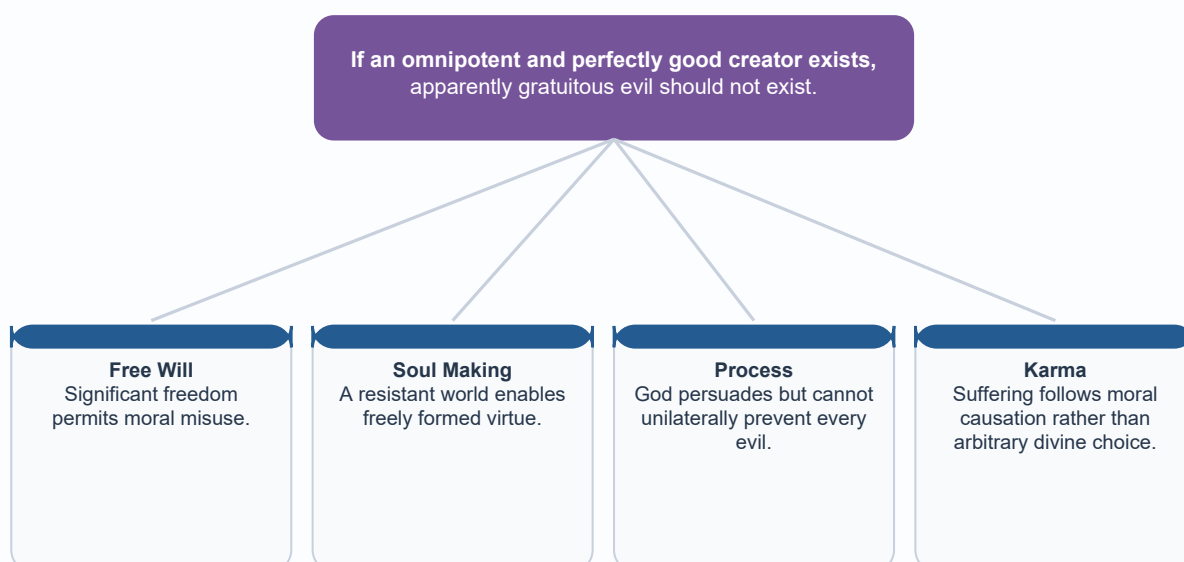
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FORMS AND RESPONSES

EVIL AS A TEST OF DIVINE POWER, KNOWLEDGE AND GOODNESS

Logical Problem Claims an inconsistency among God, goodness, power and evil.	Evidential Problem Claims the amount and distribution of suffering make God improbable.
Moral Evil Wrongdoing produced through creaturely agency.	Natural Evil Disease, disaster and suffering not directly chosen by humans.
Theodicy Offers a positive account of why God permits evil.	Defence Shows logical compatibility without claiming the actual divine reason.

THE INCONSISTENT-TRIAD PRESSURE



STATIC THEORY

- **Logical formulation:** evil is alleged to contradict omnipotent goodness when hidden premises say good always eliminates evil and power has no limits.
- **Evidential formulation:** even if compatible, horrendous and apparently pointless suffering lowers the probability of such a God.
- **Existential dimension:** philosophical consistency does not remove protest, grief or pastoral difficulty.
- **Concept-dependence:** change the concept of God, creation or evil and the problem changes.

MEMORY HOOK

L-E-M-N: Logical/Evidential and Moral/Natural. Diagnose the problem before selecting a theodicy.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. A defence seeks logical possibility; a theodicy claims a plausible actual reason.
2. Free-will accounts directly address moral evil more easily than natural evil.
3. Augustine treats evil as privation of good rather than a created substance.
4. Hick develops an Irenaean soul-making approach with epistemic distance.

UPSC TRAPS

- WRONG:** Evil is only moral wrongdoing.
- CORRECT:** The syllabus debate includes natural, horrendous and apparently gratuitous suffering.
- WRONG:** Plantinga offers a full explanation of every evil.
- CORRECT:** The free-will defence primarily targets logical compatibility.

SYLLABUS AND CONCEPT LINKS

Core Concept	Linked Debate	Answer Use
Omni-attributes	Notions of God	The problem depends on the asserted God-concept.
Free will	Religion and morality	Links moral responsibility to creaturely agency.
Karma and rebirth	Soul and liberation	Explains trans-life distribution of suffering.
Evidential reasoning	Proofs for God	Evil can count as evidence against design or goodness.

MAINS ANGLE

The logical problem can be weakened by coherent defences, but the evidential and existential force of horrendous suffering remains.

STUDY LINK

Problem of Evil.

HIGH

Core Concepts, Vocabulary and Internal Logic

Paper II
Philosophy

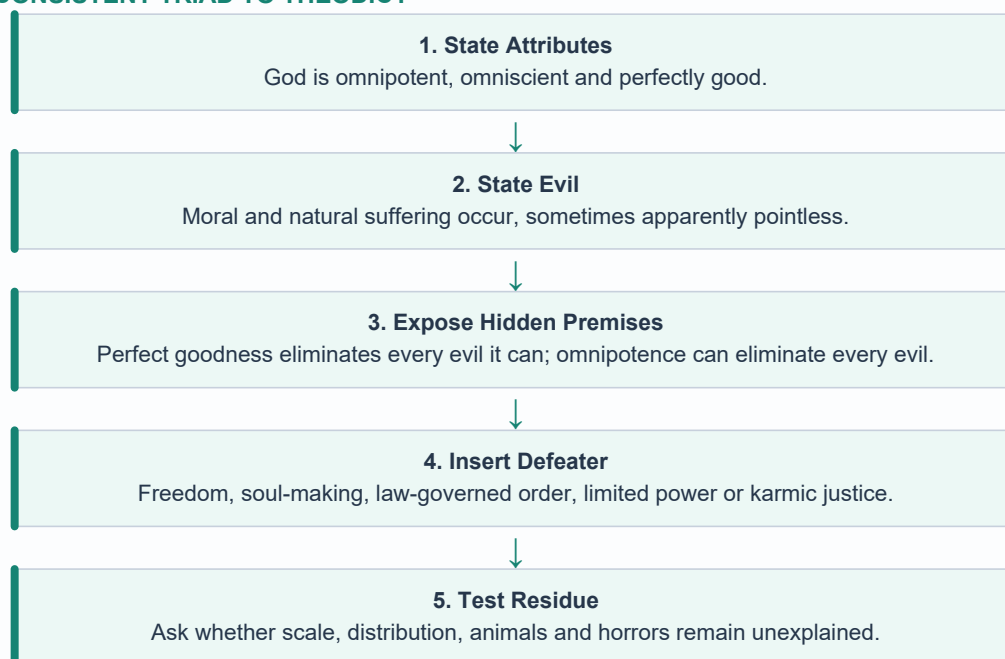
INTRO & ORIGIN

A complete answer identifies the target argument before introducing theodicies.

Definitions are followed by the argument's premises and conclusion so that the doctrine can be reconstructed rather than merely named.

KEY DATA

Term / Position	Precise Meaning	Exam Use
Logical evil	Alleged contradiction between classical God and any evil.	Mackie-style formulation.
Evidential evil	Suffering makes God improbable without strict contradiction.	Rowe-style formulation.
Moral evil	Evil resulting from responsible agency.	Free-will defence.
Natural evil	Suffering arising through natural processes.	Tests free-will adequacy.
Privatio boni	Evil is absence/corruption of due good.	Augustinian ontology.
Epistemic distance	God is not overwhelmingly obvious, allowing free moral growth.	Hick's soul-making.
Gratuitous evil	Evil apparently unnecessary for a greater good or prevention of worse evil.	Evidential challenge.

FROM INCONSISTENT TRIAD TO THEODICY**STATIC THEORY**

- **Augustinian route:** creation is good; evil enters through deficient will; punishment follows sin. Natural evil is linked to a fallen order.
- **Irenaean-Hick route:** humans are created immature and develop through real challenge; ready-made virtue would lack freedom.
- **Process route:** every actual entity has some self-determination; God supplies persuasive possibilities and suffers with creation.
- **Indian route:** karma distributes consequences across lives; non-theistic systems avoid blaming a creator altogether.

MEMORY HOOK

F-S-P-K: Free will, Soul making, Process, Karma. Match each to the kind of evil it explains.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Process theodicy limits coercive omnipotence and stresses divine persuasion.
2. Karma explains suffering through trans-life moral causation but raises victim-blaming concerns.
3. The evidential problem can remain after the strict logical contradiction is answered.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Privation means suffering is unreal.

CORRECT: It means evil lacks independent positive being, not that pain is illusory.

WRONG: Karma automatically solves evil.

CORRECT: It relocates responsibility but faces regress, evidence and compassion objections.

MAINS ANGLE

A theodicy should be judged by explanatory reach and moral cost, not merely by logical possibility.

STUDY LINK

Use this card for definition, exposition and premise-conclusion reconstruction.

HIGH**Classical, Contemporary and Indian Perspectives**Paper II
Philosophy**INTRO & ORIGIN**

Theodicies preserve different divine attributes and therefore pay different conceptual prices.

The comparison matrix keeps similarities and differences on the same axes; Indian positions are included where they alter the structure of the debate.

KEY DATA

Response	What It Preserves	Residual Difficulty
Augustinian	God creates only good; creaturely will corrupts.	Natural evil, inherited guilt and innocent suffering.
Free-will defence	Power, goodness and significant freedom.	Natural evil and heaven's freedom.
Soul-making	Goodness gives suffering a developmental purpose.	Excess, horrendous suffering and animal pain.
Process	Divine goodness and relational presence.	Relinquishes classical unilateral omnipotence.
Karma	Moral order and agent responsibility across lives.	Victim blaming, unverifiability and beginningless regress.
Advaita/Buddhist reframing	Dissolves creator-centred contradiction.	May not answer the lived reality of suffering.

STATIC THEORY

- **Classical defence:** God permits evil for freedom or greater goods without causing it as evil.
- **Contemporary evidential focus:** the key issue is not any evil but apparently unnecessary horrors.
- **Indian contrast:** dukkha and karma may be central without an omnipotent creator, so the Western inconsistent triad does not arise unchanged.

MEMORY HOOK

Ask of every response: Which evil? Which attribute? What cost?

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Free will can explain chosen wrong without making every consequence proportional.
2. Stable natural laws aid agency but also permit natural harm.
3. A non-creator conception of ultimate reality changes rather than directly answers the classical problem.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Using karma as divine punishment in every Indian school.

CORRECT: Karma may be impersonal; Nyaya adds a divine dispenser, Buddhism does not.

WRONG: Saying process God is simply weak.

CORRECT: Process thought redefines power as persuasive and relational.

CROSS-PAPER ENRICHMENT

Paper-II Theme	Paper-I / Indian Link	Value Added
Augustine	Free will and moral responsibility	Use privation and misuse of will distinctly.
Karma	Indian self and rebirth	Connect responsibility with continuity across lives.
Dukkha	Buddhism	Reframe the task from justifying God to ending suffering.

MAINS ANGLE

No theodicy explains every case without cost; combined defences improve scope but risk ad hoc accumulation.

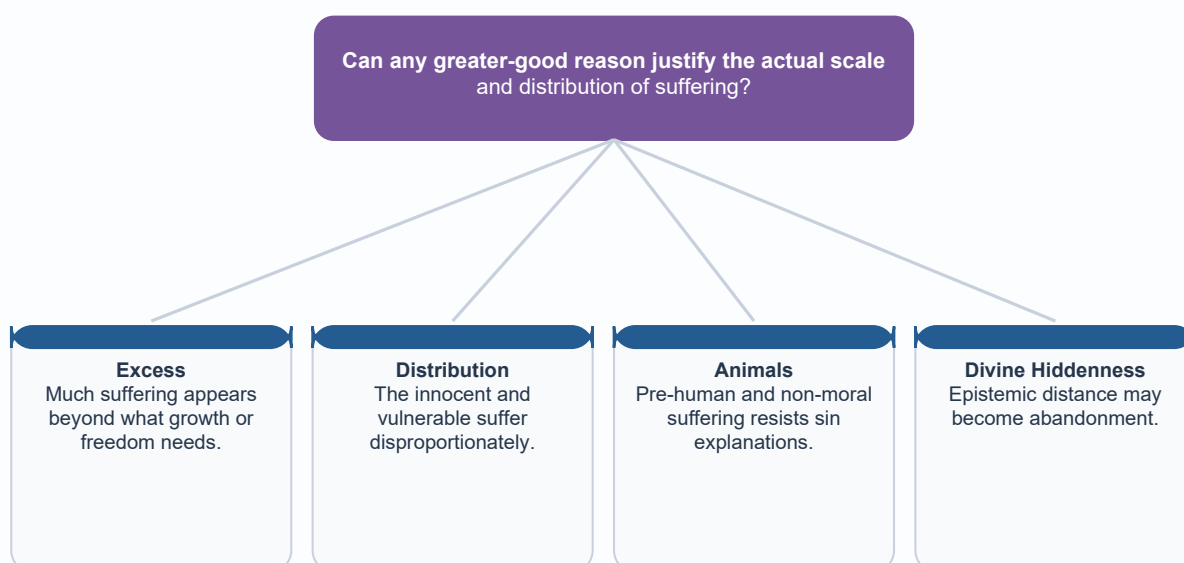
STUDY LINK

Deploy one Western and one Indian comparison only when it sharpens the question.

HIGH**Objections, Replies and Qualified Assessment**Paper II
Philosophy**INTRO & ORIGIN**

The hard cases are natural evil, animals, disproportionate suffering and horrors that seem to destroy rather than build persons.

A strong answer presents the strongest objection in its best form, then tests the reply without treating either side as automatically decisive.

OBJECTION-REPLY STRUCTURE

KEY DATA

Objection	Reply / Qualification	Final Assessment
Free will cannot explain earthquakes	Law-governed nature is a condition of meaningful action.	It explains regularity but not every magnitude or victim.
Soul-making instrumentalises victims	Virtues such as courage and compassion require vulnerability.	Some horrors crush agency and cannot be treated as mere lessons.
Privation is verbal evasion	Ontological dependence distinguishes evil from a created rival substance.	The classification does not by itself justify suffering.
Process abandons God	A non-coercive God preserves love and shared suffering.	It solves culpability by revising classical omnipotence.
Karma blames sufferers	Karma stresses responsibility and long moral horizons.	Without memory or evidence, compassionate use requires strict caution.

STATIC THEORY

- **Sceptical theism:** human cognitive limits may block inference from 'we see no reason' to 'there is no reason'.
- **Reply to sceptical theism:** too much scepticism threatens ordinary moral reasoning and confidence in divine goodness.
- **Qualified verdict:** compatibility is easier to show than a morally satisfying account of horrors.

MEMORY HOOK

COMPATIBLE is not JUSTIFIED; a defence may defeat contradiction without explaining the actual world.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. The logical and evidential problems require different standards of response.
2. Natural-law and free-will explanations can be combined but should not be conflated.
3. A good conclusion recognises the difference between intellectual and existential resolution.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Saying evil proves God does not exist.

CORRECT: It may support logical or probabilistic arguments; state which.

WRONG: Calling every suffering soul-making.

CORRECT: Test proportionality, agency and destructive cases.

MAINS ANGLE

The strongest theistic position is modest: it can offer coherent reasons for permission, not a transparent justification of every horror.

STUDY LINK

Write criticism as a debate: objection, defence, residual difficulty.

HIGH**Verified PYQs and Applied Drills**

Paper II
Philosophy

INTRO & ORIGIN

The following routes reproduce the verified demand of UPSC Philosophy Optional Paper II, Section B. Drills convert recurring formulations into practice prompts.

PYQ wording and marks are cross-checked against the local 2022-2025 question-paper PDFs and the verified _PYQ-PhilosophyOfReligion-2022-2025.md bank.

KEY DATA

Year / Marks	Verified PYQ Route	Core Demand
2022 / 15	If God is the Absolute Creator, responsibility for evil cannot belong to the human agent.	Creation, freedom and responsibility.
2023 / 20	All evil is either sin or punishment for sin - Augustine.	Privation, Fall and critique.
2024 / 15	The problem of evil is an offshoot of how God is conceptualised.	Concept-dependence of the challenge.
2025 / 15	Explain the main tenets of Process Theodicy.	Persuasion, limited coercion and divine suffering.

STATIC THEORY

- **Applied drill 1:** Does Plantinga answer the evidential problem of evil?
- **Applied drill 2:** Can soul-making justify animal suffering?
- **Applied drill 3:** Compare process theodicy with an impersonal karma doctrine.
- **Applied drill 4:** Is the problem of evil stronger against classical theism than against panentheism?

MEMORY HOOK

Read the directive first: discuss = balanced exposition; examine = test the claim; critically evaluate = objection, reply and judgement.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Use the exact syllabus vocabulary in the introduction.
2. Distinguish exposition from evaluation with explicit transitions.
3. A statement question must first interpret the statement's philosophical assumption.
4. Never invent quotations; paraphrase unless wording is securely verified.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Listing thinkers without reconstructing their reasons.

CORRECT: Build at least one explicit premise-conclusion chain.

WRONG: Using Indian material as an ornamental final paragraph.

CORRECT: Integrate it where it changes the conceptual issue.

MAINS ANGLE

Every evil answer should diagnose the God-concept and the type of evil before evaluating the response.

STUDY LINK

Revise the PYQ rows alongside the doctrine and dialectic cards.

HIGH

10/15/20-Mark Answer Frameworks

Paper II
Philosophy

INTRO & ORIGIN

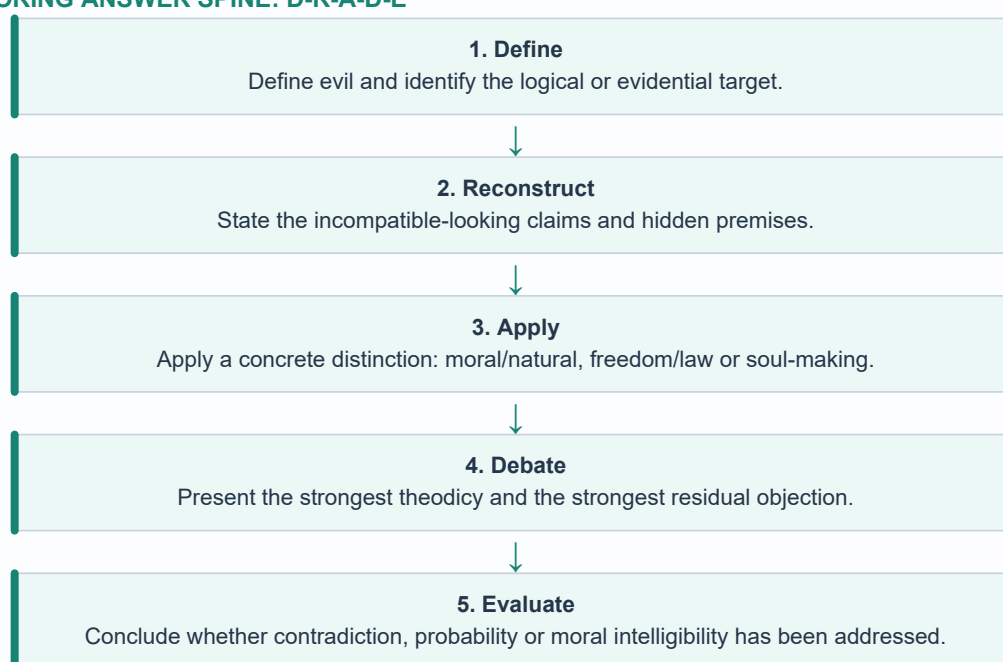
Answer length changes the depth of reconstruction and debate, not the accuracy of the doctrine. Every framework follows Define-Reconstruct-Apply-Debate-Evaluate.

These are answer architectures, not model answers to memorise verbatim.

KEY DATA

Marks	Recommended Architecture	Non-Negotiable
10	State logical/evidential form; explain one response; raise one residual objection; qualify.	One precise distinction and one criticism.
15	Diagnose the God-concept; reconstruct two responses; test natural evil and distribution; conclude on cost.	Internal logic, comparison and qualified judgement.
20	Build the inconsistent triad; separate logical/evidential and moral/natural; compare Western theodicies and karma; assess horrors and divine attributes.	Full dialectic, Indian-Western bridge and defended conclusion.

HIGH-SCORING ANSWER SPINE: D-R-A-D-E



STATIC THEORY

- **High-value distinction:** defence versus theodicy.
- **Indian bridge:** creator-centred evil is transformed in karma and non-theistic liberation systems.
- **Qualified close:** logical compatibility does not erase evidential or existential force.

MEMORY HOOK

Conclude: The response defeats ____ but leaves ____; it preserves divine ____ at the cost of ____.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. 10 marks: approximately 150 words; prioritise precision over range.
2. 15 marks: add one comparison and a developed objection-reply.
3. 20 marks: organise the answer around a philosophical problem, not a catalogue.
4. The conclusion must answer the exact necessity, possibility or truth claim asked.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Giving the same compressed answer for every mark value.

CORRECT: Increase depth of reconstruction, criticism and synthesis with marks.

WRONG: Ending with 'both views are important'.

CORRECT: State what survives criticism and under what qualification.

MAINS ANGLE

The logical problem can be weakened by coherent defences, but the evidential and existential force of horrendous suffering remains.

STUDY LINK

Final revision: master map -> argument -> comparison -> objection/reply -> PYQ answer spine.

End of Register Notes — UPSC Agent / Copilot CLI